



would stop the clock at 44.98 to become the first Indian man to break the 45-second barrier in the 400m. Then, at 8.10 pm, Tejaswin Shankar scaled one of the defining peaks of track and field, becoming the country's first decathlete to cross 8,000 points, totalling 8057 points.

While each of the performances was a watershed moment in its own right, they had been building up steadily.

For many years, the Indian record had stagnated around the 10.30 mark (set by Anil Kumar in 2005). It was over a decade before that mark was brought down to 10.26 (by Amiya Mallick in 2016). It took another six years for the record to be lowered by a further hundredth of a second (by Amlan Borgohain in 2022).

In the last couple of years,

however, the rate of progress had gathered momentum. Manikanta Hoblidhar had run a 10.23 race in 2023. Then, last year, Gurindervir Singh (10.20) and Animesh Kujur (10.18) pulled the mark even lower.

None of that would compare to what would happen at the Federation Cup. Gurindervir's mark on the 23rd was, in fact, the third time the Indian 100m record had fallen in the space of a day. Running in the semifinals a couple of days prior, the 25-year-old from Jalandhar had erased a hundredth of a second off Kujur's then record of 10.18 seconds. Less than five minutes later, however, Kujur had reclaimed the record with a time of 10.15 seconds.

On that day, Gurindervir had eased up some 20 metres before the finish, which stopped him from running even faster and left open a

window through which Kujur had burst. It was clear that Gurindervir had left the track with unfinished business.

There was nothing left to chance on that Saturday. He had stayed off social media. He kept to himself in the hours before the race, his ears plugged with earbuds so that he wouldn't be disturbed in the warm-up area. He had kept his mind laser-focused on the race he had to run. When the starter's pistol fired, he performed flawlessly. Gurindervir got off the blocks fast, pulled clear of the runners in every other lane by the 40m mark, kept his foot on the gas all the way through and bent forward at the finish line.

As he blitzed past the finish line, the flash timing on the digital board at the Birs Munda Stadium showed 10.07 seconds. A few seconds later,